

DA ONLY — EYES ONLY

CASE BRIEF — THE HEAVENLY CRUCIFIX

Region: Central Europe (Prague, Vienna, Munich, Bavarian Forest)

Case Duration: 10 days (columns 10 → 1)

Artifact: The Crucifix of St. Vitus (Tier 2 — Threatening)

Sessions: 2–4

MYSTERY STATEMENT

"A Tier 2 artifact — the Crucifix of St. Vitus — has been stolen from Prague Castle and replaced with a professional forgery. The thieves, brokered by the Vantablack Compact, are selling it to Andy Warhol, who survived a 1968 shooting and has been searching for guaranteed protection ever since. The Catholic Church, led by Cardinal Voss of the Congregation for the Doctrine of the Faith, has deployed a recovery team — viewing the crucifix as proof of divine favor. Meanwhile, the original meteoric iron from which the crucifix was forged lies beneath a pagan shrine in the Bohemian Forest. If the sale completes, the bearer will become psychologically unstable from 'immortality mania.' If the Church recovers the crucifix before the Covenant, they will either weaponize it or destroy it to suppress its pagan origin. If anyone locates the shrine site, additional fragments of the iron can be harvested — making this a replicable threat."

THE REAL STORY

What the Crucifix Is

The Crucifix of St. Vitus is not a Christian relic. The iron was smelted from a meteorite that struck the Bohemian Forest around 900 CE — witnessed by a Slavic pagan community who built a shrine at the impact site. They believed the iron was a fragment of the sky-god's armor. When Christianity arrived, the shrine was demolished, the iron was reforged into a crucifix, and the pagan origin was buried under hagiography. The *effect* — immunity to bodily harm — is intrinsic to the meteoric iron. It is not divine. It is material that does not belong on Earth. The property activates when the iron is worn against skin.

What Happened

Six weeks ago, a professional crew stole the crucifix from the Prague Castle chapel museum, replacing it with an exceptional forgery. The theft went unnoticed until a Covenant routine audit detected an anomalous signature in Vienna. The crucifix emits a Corruption signature only when worn – the Vienna spike was the thief testing it: letting himself be hit, thrown down stairs, convinced of his invincibility.

The Compact is brokering the sale. The buyer – revealed late in the case – is Andy Warhol, who has been searching for a guarantee against violence since Valerie Solanas shot him in 1968. The Church learned of the theft through independent means and deployed Cardinal Voss's team. The current bearer (Klaus Reiner, the lead thief) has been wearing the crucifix continuously for two weeks and is entering early-stage immortality mania.

The Shrine Site

The original meteorite impact site is a lost pagan shrine in the Bohemian Forest, deliberately erased from records by the medieval Church. Countess Martinice, the last surviving member of the family that guarded the crucifix for centuries, holds letters and a family tree that trace the crucifix back to the shrine. If the agents follow this thread, they discover that the meteorite was not a single fragment – there is *more iron* at the shrine site. Each fragment, if forged into an object and worn, would grant the same immortality property. This changes the classification from "unique relic" to "raw material with replicable properties."

RESOLUTION PATHS

Contain (Covenant Objective)

The agents recover the crucifix before the exchange and deliver it to a Keep vault. The shrine site is mapped and sealed. The Church never gets confirmation of the crucifix's true nature. Warhol returns to New York, unaware of how close he came.

Deny Use

The agents prevent the sale but cannot recover the crucifix. If the thief is neutralized (immobilized without killing – which is impossible to do with conventional violence), the crucifix can be removed from his neck while he is unconscious or restrained. If the Church recovers it, the agents must intercept before the Vatican takes possession.

Witness and Report

The exchange happens. Warhol acquires the crucifix. The agents document the transfer and file a containment failure report. The Covenant has to decide whether to attempt a second recovery from a celebrity civilian – a diplomatic and operational nightmare. This is a "case with a scar": the Decay track advances, but the cost is paid.

Catastrophe

The thief's immortality mania escalates at the exchange. He challenges everyone present to kill him – and they try. Multiple deaths. The crucifix is lost in the chaos. The Compact disappears. The Church covers up its involvement. The Covenant is blamed for a bloodbath on European soil. The Decay track advances by 3.

DA CHECKLIST – BEFORE SESSION 1

TASK	DONE
Print Operations Board + Organization Reference	☐
Print Location Pages L1–L7	☐
Print NPC Cards NPC1–NPC8	☐
Print and cut Information Cards I1–I22	☐
Print Relic Sheet	☐
Give players Case Brief – Player	☐
Start clock: Day 10, Morning	☐

KEY DRAMATIC BEATS

1. **Day 10–9:** The agents arrive in Prague. They discover the theft, the forgery, and the trail leading to Countess Martinice in Brno.
2. **Day 8:** Relic Milestone – signature spikes in Vienna. The thief is testing the crucifix. Agents can trace it.
3. **Day 7–6:** The Church team becomes visible. Cardinal Voss is cooperative on the surface, obstructive underneath. Players may realize the Church wants the crucifix for its own reasons.
4. **Day 5:** Relic Milestone – immortality mania. The thief escalates. Reckless behavior. The Compact gets nervous.
5. **Day 4–2:** The trail leads to the Bohemian Forest shrine site (if the agents followed the Countess's letters) and/or the buyer's identity becomes clear (if they followed the Compact's money trail).
6. **Day 1:** Catastrophe – the exchange at the Bavarian hunting lodge. Three-way standoff. Warhol is in the parking lot. The thief is invincible and manic. The Church team is closing in. Everything comes together.

RUNNING THE THREE-WAY STANDOFF

The hunting lodge scene is the climax. Manage it as a single extended scene, not a combat. The thief (Klaus Reiner) wants to complete the sale and disappear. The Compact broker (Elena Varga) wants to close the deal and collect her fee. The Church team wants the crucifix. Warhol wants to be handed the crucifix and leave. The agents want containment.

Reiner cannot be killed or physically harmed. He *knows* this. He will stand in the middle of the room and invite violence. The agents' options: convince him to remove the crucifix voluntarily (Manipulate, Difficulty 3 – his entire identity is now wrapped up in being invincible), physically restrain and sedate him (Brawl or Force to grapple, Heal to sedate – he's not superhumanly strong, just unkillable), or let the Church team try their approach (Cardinal Voss believes he can talk Reiner down – he's wrong, but his attempt buys the agents time).

If Warhol enters the scene, he is frail, polite, and utterly convinced this is meant to be. He does not fight. He does not run. He just waits to see if someone hands him the thing that means he never has to be afraid again.